0170 RPO Way
New Brunswick, NJ 08901

December 14, 2022

Jeanne Kingsley
President
Berkeley Heights Township Council
29 Park Avenue
Berkeley Heights, NJ
07922

Dear Ms. Kingsley:

Thank you for attending my presentation on November 21st. I hope you gained some valuable insight into the challenges minorities face at Berkeley Heights Public Schools. With a specialty in finance and strategic planning and a mission to make Berkeley Heights the best town for families to live in, your values and experience align with my plan to integrate cultural competency in Berkeley Heights. As the president of the Berkeley Heights Council, I urge you to consider allocating the school budget to a cultural competency program.

Despite its strong academic reputation, Berkeley Heights Public Schools are often associated with an environment that ranges from uncomfortable to hostile for minority students. Much of this discrimination results from microaggressions, persistent and often unacknowledged barriers for minority groups. Persistent discrimination such as that found in environments with microaggressions is associated with twice the risk of having two mental disorders and three times the risk of having three or more disorders (Williams, 2018). Microaggressions can cause and verify feelings of otherness and isolation, induce health problems such as depression, anxiety, and cardiovascular disease, and create a stressful and risky environment for its victims (Berk, 2017). However, we can stop these threats at their source through proper educational measures.

With your help, an integration of cultural competency into the school system would ensure both: the safety of minority students through the reduction of microaggressions; and necessary multicultural, critical thinking, and interpersonal skills for the entire student body.

Your consideration would allow for the better education, understanding, and safety of Berkeley Heights children. The integration of an efficient cultural competency program would allow students to learn more about their peers and cultivate a safe environment for all students, ensuring their success in the classroom and beyond. I can be reached with any questions, comments, or concerns at rap327@scarletmail.rutgers.edu. I hope we will have the opportunity to work together to make Berkeley Heights Public Schools a safe and inclusive community.

Sincerely,
Rachael Prokap
Rachael Prokap

Cultural competency: Addressing the health and safety of minority groups in Berkeley Heights, New Jersey

Submitted by:
Rachael Prokap

Submitted to:
Jeanne Kingsley
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29 Park Avenue
Berkeley Heights, NJ 07922

December 14, 2022

Prepared for:
Writing for Business and the Professions
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Abstract

Thorough research and examination of patterns of discrimination have demonstrated the disadvantages placed on minorities but also emphasized hope for effective solutions. Despite outstanding academic performance, there are areas where the Berkeley Heights Public School (BHPS) system falls short. Berkeley Heights students have reported discrimination and a lack of equity toward minority students. Persistent, possibly unintentional, and often unacknowledged forms of discrimination known as microaggressions are rampant in BHPS schools. These acts of aggression lead to increased risk of student safety: for instance, in increased risks of mental and physical health disorders such as post-traumatic stress disorder, depression, anxiety, cardiovascular disorder, et cetera (Bale & Jovanovic, 2021).

Studies of cultural competency have demonstrated their effectiveness in increasing multiculturalism and interpersonal relationships within student bodies. Integrating conversations about contemporary cultural issues have demonstrated significant improvement in the critical-thinking and cultural competence skills of middle-school students (Boyd & Miller, 2020). Similar results of minority support and an overall better well-rounded education were demonstrated when students were surrounded by faculty and peers with a greater understanding of culture and identity (Ingraham, Davidson, & Yonge, 2018). Teacher certification programs are highly effective in improving teachers' cultural competency scores. Adjustments to the Berkeley Heights Public Schools district and curricula could prove similarly drastic improvements of cultural competency and minority safety.

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Executive Summary

Middle-class suburban towns, such as Berkeley Heights, often have a significant disparity between the understanding and inclusion of the majority-white population and any minority groups (Boyd & Miller, 2020). Changes are necessary to diminish these disparities and ensure the proper development of children, which should be a priority to the education system; teaching the youth is how effective systematic changes are made (Suttie, 2017). An important step for the Berkeley Heights township to take toward an environment of inclusion and growth is education that addresses and eliminates microaggressions in the school system. Working to reduce microaggressions in Berkeley Heights Public Schools would improve the well-being and long-term outlook of minority students.

The stress from microaggressions goes beyond short-term emotional damage. Recent studies suggest those affected by racism are placed in a chronic state of stress, with a significantly higher risk of developing PTSD, suicidal thoughts and behaviors, and other mental health disorders (Bale & Jovanovic, 2021). Macroaggressions, what people most associate with discrimination, are explicit forms of racism. Mircoaggressions, persistent, possibly unintentional, and prejudiced actions, however, tend to be taken with less severity despite their harm (Berk, 2017). Microaggressions can cause and verify feelings of otherness and isolation, induce health problems such as depression, anxiety, and cardiovascular disease, and create a stressful and risky environment for its victims (Berk, 2017). Part of the danger of microaggressions is when they are taken lightly, as they are often ignored or accepted as harmless. However, research suggests that they have significant acute- and long-term effects which must be addressed.

Environments where minorities feel othered are not only inconvenient but dangerous. The leading cause of this detrimental risk in the mental health of minority students was found to be acculturation: when one feels as if they are losing their values, culture, and identity. By reducing microaggressions, students are less likely to feel forcibly assimilated (Rudes & Fantuzzi, 2017). Students should feel welcome in their cultural identities and express these significant aspects of their family and individual lives without fear of consequence. Eliminating microaggressions would not only alleviate temporary stress but ensure the long-term well-being of students.

The community and education of Berkeley Heights does not sufficiently address cultural competency. Previous students of the Berkeley Heights School District's schools reflect somewhat positively in general, but also clearly outline the issues in student life. I interviewed 14 alumni, each of whom experienced or witnessed an act of aggression due to one's identity as part of a minority group. Students remarked that they heard their peers misusing slurs or making hurtful racially-motivated comments. For instance, an alum attested that she faced disciplinary action after calling out a coach for making a racist remark toward her. Several other graduates of Berkeley Heights noted instances they overheard slurs used in casual conversation. Others noted times they were referred to with blatantly discriminatory stereotypes. Another alum remarked that many of his peers told him, unprompted, not to eat their dogs because of his Asian background. A different Asian student said he was constantly compared to Chinese basketball player Yao Ming whenever he participated in sports.

Microaggressions can be significantly reduced but must be done so in a way that allows minority students to "self-disclose their experiences of microaggressions in ways that elicit individuation

and build empathy" (Ensari et al., 2012). In order for microaggressions to be combatted, and for minority students to therefore have a greater educational experience and outlook, they must be brought into a conversation. Majority students must understand microaggressions in order for them to be combatted. Further research suggests that this understanding is necessary to develop understanding and respectful individuals, which should be a goal of the Berkeley Heights Public School system. People typically respond with "[indifference]…upon witnessing a racist act against an out-group", and this indifference is replaced with action and support when the victim is understood (Keels, Durkee, & Hope, 2017). Increasing discussion and understanding of microaggressions in the classroom will effectively work toward eliminating racism in the school environment (Ensari et al., 2012).

Beyond eliminating prejudice in students, cultural competency education would aid in the emotional and social development of students (Hall, & Theriot, 2016). Multiculturalism is a significant skill, especially in contemporary educational and occupational settings. The population continuously grows more diverse, which makes cultural competency education more relevant; this necessitates educators to take on the responsibility of ensuring students can perform properly in diverse settings. Many people lack the necessary cultural competency skills "in a time when these qualities are most needed", and discussions about diversity and culture in the classroom have been found to significantly improve necessary multicultural skills (Hall, & Theriot, 2016).

Exposure to diverse groups and discussions of such– acknowledgement of differing lifestyles and traditions, for instance– can greatly improve students' cultural competency and should be implemented in schools (Boyd & Miller, 2020). A Director of Diversity taking from all these previous successful models would be most effective. Cultural competency education would focus on ensuring teachers are well-educated and trustworthy, open resources for the children; pushing inclusion and representation of cultural customs; ensuring that minority groups are more aware of and are given the opportunities to engage in helpful educational programs typically dominated by a specific group. The Director of Diversity for Berkeley Heights would ensure the well-being of all students, working hands-on to ensure the best experience for students in their K-12 education and beyond.

A plan encompassing all students' needs, while still being practical, applicable, and appropriate, is essential to the betterment of Berkeley Heights Public Schools students. A thoughtful, flexible, and unique integration of cultural competency education is possible by establishing cultural competency throughout every level of the school: for students, faculty, parents, and the overall district. The research demonstrates not only the effectiveness but the necessity of classroom integration, faculty training, parent support, and the guidance of a director of diversity. Integrating cultural competency on all necessary levels would call for a budget of $167,800.

A culturally competent community is imperative to the student body's outlook. By specifically implementing methods of microaggression reduction, student safety and development will be prioritized. Students suffering from persistent, unacknowledged discrimination are adversely affected mentally, physically, and academically. To prioritize multiculturalism is to prioritize BHPS students.

Introduction

Middle-class suburban towns, such as Berkeley Heights, often have a significant disparity between the understanding and inclusion of the majority-white population and any minority groups (Boyd & Miller, 2020). Changes are necessary to diminish these disparities and ensure the proper development of children, which should be a priority to the education system; teaching the youth is how effective systematic changes are made (Suttie, 2017). An important step for the Berkeley Heights township to take toward an environment of inclusion and growth is education that addresses and eliminates microaggressions in the school system. Working to reduce microaggressions in Berkeley Heights Public Schools (BHPS) would improve the well-being and long-term outlook of minority students.

The short- and long-term biological effects of discrimination

The stress from microaggressions goes beyond short-term emotional damage. Recent studies suggest those affected by racism are placed in a chronic state of stress, with a significantly higher risk of developing PTSD, suicidal thoughts and behaviors, and other mental health disorders (Bale & Jovanovic, 2021). Macroaggressions, what people most associate with discrimination, are explicit forms of racism. Mircoaggressions, persistent, possibly unintentional, and prejudiced actions, however, tend to be taken with less severity despite their harm (Berk, 2017). Persistent discrimination such as that found in environments with microaggressions is associated with twice the risk of having two mental disorders and three times the risk of having three or more disorders (Williams, 2018). Microaggressions can cause and verify feelings of otherness and isolation, induce health problems such as depression, anxiety, and cardiovascular disease, and create a stressful and risky environment for its victims (Berk, 2017). Part of the danger of microaggressions is when they are taken lightly, as they are often ignored or accepted as harmless. However, research suggests that they have significant acute- and long-term effects which must be addressed.

A comprehensive study by the American Psychological Association (APA) similarly supports that stress levels are significantly higher for those who experience discrimination. People who experienced discrimination had significantly higher reported stress levels. The below figure demonstrates the reported stress between individuals who have and have not experienced discrimination from different ethnicities. The reported difference in stress levels between those who have not and those who have experienced discrimination shows a 30% increase in white individuals; an 18% increase in hispanic individuals; and a staggering 37% increase in black individuals (APA, 2015).

Beyond increased risk for health conditions, stress leads to changes in the attitudes and even behaviors of affected groups. APA's statistics additionally demonstrate that 31% of Hispanic and 29% of Black adults feel they must go out of their way to receive good service and avoid harassment (2015). Additionally, 23% of Blacks, 21% of Hispanics, and 15% of Asians and Whites reported feeling it necessary to prepare for possible insults and harassment before leaving the house (APA, 2015). While race does not necessarily determine the level of stress and discrimination an individual will face, nor whether they identify as part of a minority group (for instance, religiously or in their sexual or gender identity), the effects of discrimination are apparent and substantial.

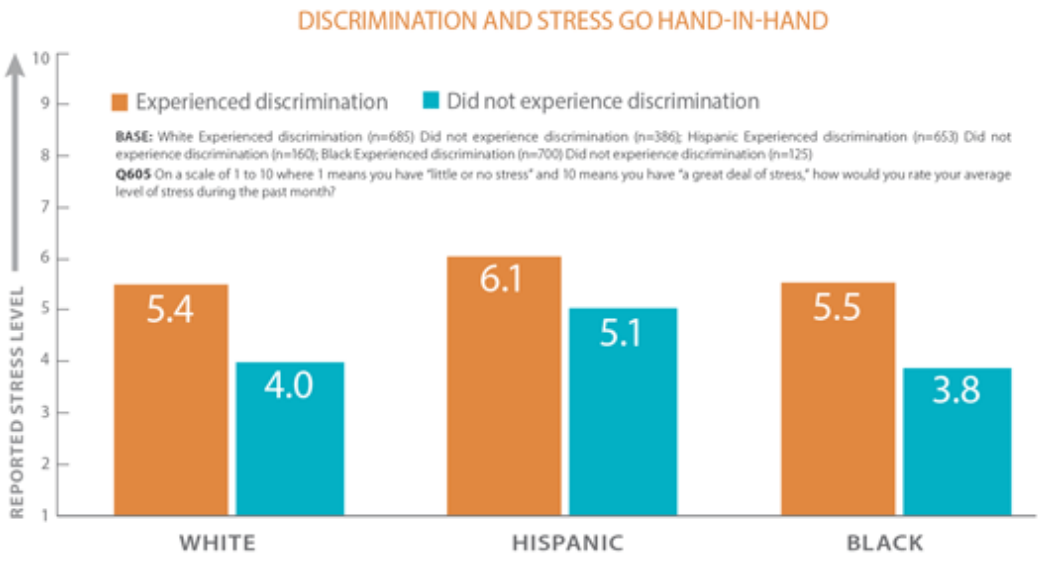

Figure 1: The difference in stress between individuals who have and have not experienced discrimination (APA, 2015).

The American Psychological Association's follow-up on emotional support additionally heavily coincides with the necessity for cultural competence in schools. The study found that emotional support was significant in increasing individuals' "coping abilities with discrimination" (APA, 2015). 65% of adults with emotional support coped quite or very well with discrimination, as opposed to only 37% of those who did not have emotional support. Additionally, those without emotional support had significantly higher stress levels, with a 6.3 average compared to the average of 5.0 for those with emotional support, or a 21% increase (APA, 2015). Support specifically for students facing discrimination is a crucial resource for the student body.

Environments where minorities feel othered are not only inconvenient but dangerous. The leading cause of this detrimental risk in the mental health of minority students was found to be acculturation: when one feels as if they are losing their values, culture, and identity. By reducing microaggressions, students are less likely to feel forcibly assimilated (Rudes & Fantuzzi, 2017). Students should feel welcome in their cultural identities and express these significant aspects of their family and individual lives without fear of consequence. Eliminating microaggressions would not only alleviate temporary stress but ensure the long-term well-being of students.

Microaggressions deter academic achievement

Microaggressions additionally affect students academically. Academic achievement has always been a priority to the Berkeley Heights Public Schools and should continue to be cultivated. Minority students should feel heard, respected, and be given the same academic opportunities as majority students. The physical and mental damage from microaggressions harms students' ability to act and think healthily, and studies suggest academic performance is impacted by exposure to discrimination (Keels, Durkee, & Hope, 2017). Students' perception of their school– the student body, environment, classrooms, et cetera– are impacted by their treatment at and experiences concerning the school. Students who experience discrimination have lower perceptions of the schools they attend and are therefore less likely to perform academically and

are more likely to have a higher rate of absences (Keels, Durkee, & Hope, 2017). As a significant source of stress, emotionally and academically, to minority students, microaggressions in Berkeley Heights should be addressed seriously.

Furthermore, microaggressions make students feel "alienated or silenced in small group discussions", which is unconducive to the learning environment (Berk, 2017). Students are given fewer opportunities to learn when viewed as less intelligent from prejudice. Students also feel "uncomfortable" when addressed in a disrespectful or othering way, which can make social and educational situations more stressful (Berk, 2017). Young African-American students are over twice as likely to be considered "unintelligent or violence-prone" when compared to white children of the same age (Williams, 2018). Similarly, African American and Hispanic teens are more than one-and-half-times as likely to be considered unintelligent or violence-prone than white teens and adults. Not only do majority groups tend to consider minority groups unfairly; white adults similarly stereotype minority children, and some of the most significant negative stereotyping was directed toward teenagers (Williams, 2018).

"Positive" stereotypes can be significantly harmful to students as well, as they place expectations and invisible barriers for the affected students to break. Asian students are often stereotyped as naturally being good at math, which detracts from their work, natural ability, and occasionally makes students feel like their Asian classmates are obligated to "help them with their problems" (Berk, 2017). When students are put at a disadvantage in the grade school classroom, there are lasting effects into higher education and even into their careers. Ostracization, delayed emotional development in middle and high school, and barriers on academic performance can limit the chances students have further in life in a domino effect.

Social deviance and long-term consequences

Social deviance can be demonstrated in the disparity between majority and minority groups' behavior nationwide. Stigmatization and stereotypes cause students to behave as expected from them; certain expectations are placed on students which may make them behave more or less normatively, or have more or less stress placed upon them (Shoenberger, Heckert, & Heckert, 2015). Exposure to microaggressions places a social expectation on students and their performance. How they act emotionally, academically, and socially is not solely determined by their personality and choices, but how they are labeled in society (Shoenberger, Heckert, & Heckert, 2015). This pattern can be demonstrated in a 2018 study by the United States Government Accountability Office (GAO), in which data was collected on student disciplinary action in schools. The below figure demonstrates the vast overrepresentation of black students, male students, and disabled students.

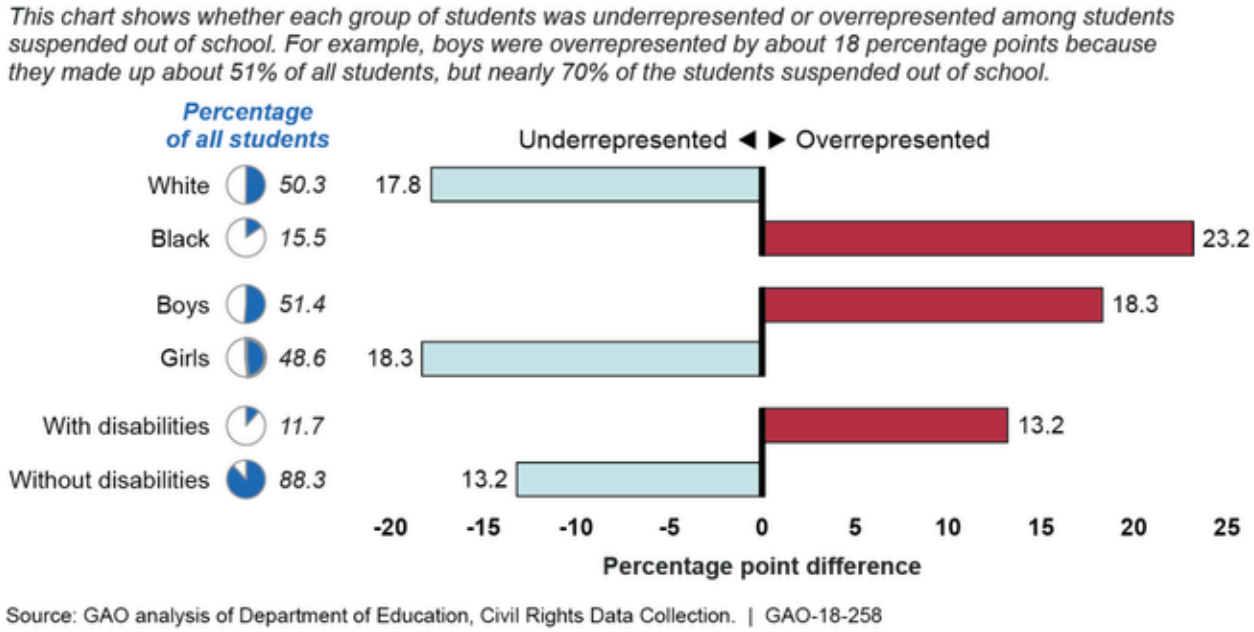

Figure 2: The US Government's statistics on representation of students of different identities suspended out of school (GAO, 2018).

Students unable to attend classes due to disciplinary action have significant setbacks on their academic and occupational outlook (Del Toro & Wang, 2021). Discrimination involving a decision with critical long-term consequences further demonstrates the harm of persistent negative stereotyping such as microaggressions (GAO, 2018). Further research suggests that students who act verbally or physically hostile towards others are disproportionately assessed as threats when they identify as a racial minority (Cornell et al., 2018). In order to ensure equity of disciplinary action and student development, faculty should be accurately trained to properly assess students from an unbiased perspective; similarly, students with a sense of belonging are less likely to act in accordance with possible aggressive stereotyping (Williams, 2018). African Americans are "grossly overrepresented" in school suspensions for minor disciplinary infractions, which results from their consideration as a greater threat (Del Toro & Wang, 2021; Williams, 2018). The first step toward a more equitable school system is broadening the understanding and education of those involved: equipping educators with the proper resources and guiding students with the proper lessons.

The presence of discrimination in Berkeley Heights: Student experiences

The community and education of Berkeley Heights does not sufficiently address cultural competency. Previous students of the Berkeley Heights School District's schools reflect somewhat positively in general, but also clearly outline the issues in student life. I interviewed 14 alumni, each of whom experienced or witnessed an act of aggression due to one's identity as part of a minority group. Students remarked that they heard their peers misusing slurs or making hurtful racially-motivated comments. For instance, an alum attested that she faced disciplinary action after calling out a coach for making a racist remark toward her. Several other graduates of Berkeley Heights noted instances they overheard slurs used in casual conversation. Others noted times they were referred to with blatantly discriminatory stereotypes. Another alum remarked that many of his peers told him, unprompted, not to eat their dogs because of his Asian

background. A different Asian student said he was constantly compared to Chinese basketball player Yao Ming whenever he participated in sports.

Students have attested that the bullying policy is needlessly unforgiving (often misconstruing friendly teasing for over bullying), but the school population is still often "cliquey" and "mean" (Niche). Minority groups still often face racism and feel othered in Berkeley Heights schools. Education is an effective way of addressing these disparities and ensuring students develop into well-rounded, respectful individuals. Many of the previous students I interviewed noted that the coursework at Berkeley Heights Public Schools were rigorous and prepared them well academically, but they ultimately looked back at the schools as discriminatory and rigid, which is a reputation we can work to change.

Governor Livingston High School (GLHS) is rated 4 stars out of 5 on niche out of 177 reviews, but nearly all the positives and negatives are consistent: the school is academically very strong, there are a wide variety of clubs, but the community is intolerant. Alum have stated that the environment is a "hard fit" due to the "large white population" (Niche, 2018). The student body is often viewed as rude, especially considering the "social stigmas" and [lack] of diversity". For instance, parent in 2020 attested that "black [students] are not supported or treated equally". According to an alum, "GL is known for having racist and discriminatory teachers [and] faculty… the few people of color are often ostracized" (Niche). GLHS is often praised for its academic standing but is ultimately held back by its lack of support for minority students. This discrimination is inhibiting students' ability to perform at their full potential in the classroom. By addressing microaggressions, GLHS will be prioritizing its students' futures.

Research Rationale

Introduction to the cultural competency curriculum

Professor Dr. C. Alex Gray, the Director of Diversity for Piscataway Township, stated in our interview that the main responsibility of the Director of Diversity is to ensure the needs of all groups of students are met. Some of his initiatives include encouraging elementary school students to interact with the special needs children; integrating discussions of race into education; and ensuring students celebrating Ramadan had activities in place of the lunch period. Dr. Gray listed his experiences and advice for towns such as Berkeley Heights; for instance, he suggested that towns focus on groups which need representation and inclusion. Notable populations in Berkeley Heights include the 11.4% Asian American population and the 6.4% Hispanic population (Census, 2020). He emphasized the need for open discussions on topics such as race and privilege to broaden students' understanding.

According to University of California, Berkeley's *Greater Good Magazine*: "[Judgments people have about differences] develop over time and are influenced by many things, including the social climate children grow up in and the experiences they have that confirm or disprove their biases" (Suttie, 2017). Dr. Jill Suttie compiles and presents research on race. She explains that children are greatly impacted by their role models and are significantly more likely to display biases if their parents do. Research has shown that these biases, overall, can be reduced by introducing and exposing children to diverse communities and talking directly about race (Suttie, 2017). By creating an environment where positive discussions about race are promoted and adults provide an example of fairness, children are less likely to grow up biased.

Education and Awareness: The Australian Government's Model

The Australian Children's Education & Care Quality Authority (ACECQA) is an independent statutory authority which works with the Australian government, particularly the early childhood sector (ACECQA, 2016). Their mission is to benefit the lives of children and families in Australia. The organization works to monitor and maintain the National Quality Standard of children's education and to uphold the *Education and Care Services National Law*, which is ensured through an anti-bias curriculum, addressing racism and injustice, and ensuring a culturally competent education system. Their cultural competence education embodies creating an environment to think critically and empathetically, fully understand and challenge one's cultural identity and beliefs, and promoting communication between and comprehension of cultural groups (ACECQA, 2016).

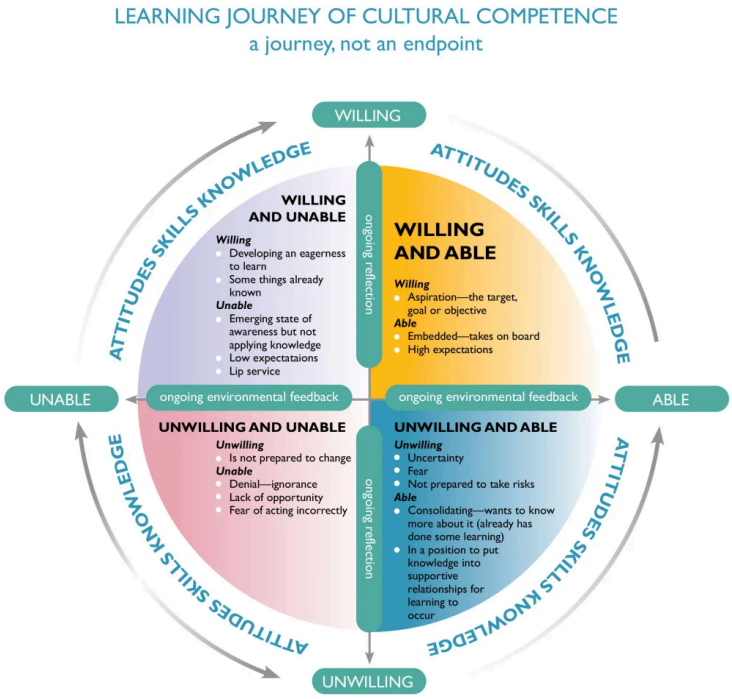

Figure 3: ACECQA's learning model for cultural competency (2016).

The curriculum focuses on certain questions for faculty: they must consider who is advantaged and disadvantaged in environments they create, the importance of cultural competence, and the backgrounds (culture and languages in particular) that the children belong to (ACECQA, 2016). With an education focused on the most recent research and guided by the organization's principle to raise awareness and provide quality education, cultural competency education is provided as a way to further children's development and outcomes. Culture is essential to a person's identity, and feeling understood and belonging is significant to childrens' development. ACECQA states that they follow the national understanding that "principles of trust, respect for diversity, equity, fairness, and social justice" are constructed upon cultural competence (2016). While the

Australian Government's model is centered mainly on consideration of the Aboriginal people, minority groups in United States education systems are disadvantaged in parallel ways. Cultural competency is an important skill that is well-educated in this model of communication and education.

Addressing microaggressions in the classroom

A paper published in *Theory into Practice* compiles decades worth of research to ascertain which policies in education cultivate legitimate change (Leonard & Woodland, 2022). Performative, small-scale activities are ultimately ineffective in properly ensuring a population is culturally competent, which is essential in educating children to work cooperatively and unbiased in a diverse environment. Teachers, especially, must understand the necessity of anti-racism and must have open spaces to discuss race and understand differences themselves. Teachers in K-12 education are not simply educating subjects such as math and language arts; they are supporting the "social-emotional development of students" (Leonard & Woodland, 2022).

Microaggressions can be significantly reduced but must be done so in a way that allows minority students to "self-disclose their experiences of microaggressions in ways that elicit individuation and build empathy" (Ensari et al., 2012). In order for microaggressions to be combatted, and for minority students to therefore have a greater educational experience and outlook, they must be brought into a conversation. Majority students must understand microaggressions in order for them to be combatted. Further research suggests that this understanding is necessary to develop understanding and respectful individuals, which should be a goal of the Berkeley Heights Public School system. People typically respond with "[indifference]…upon witnessing a racist act against an out-group", and this indifference is replaced with action and support when the victim is understood (Keels, Durkee, & Hope, 2017). Increasing discussion and understanding of microaggressions in the classroom will effectively work toward eliminating racism in the school environment (Ensari et al., 2012).

An integration of cultural competency in the classroom for children is possible in the language arts classroom (Boyd & Miller, 2020). In a 78% white, predominantly middle-class, and suburban area similar to Berkeley Heights, two 8th grade classes discussed subjects such as race and discrimination. Students, when given the opportunity to freely discuss such subjects, were more inclined to discuss and further comprehend subjects which otherwise may have never been brought up, such as police brutality and privilege. In their time in the classroom, a comprehensive unit tied necessary reading-comprehension, writing, and communication practice to effective lessons in cultural competency (Boyd & Miller, 2020). The activities studied effectively broadened students' perspectives and prompted them to think critically and empathetically. Similar education geared toward discussion about microaggressions would similarly work to relieve biases and discrimination in students.

Beyond eliminating prejudice in students, cultural competency education would aid in the emotional and social development of students (Hall, & Theriot, 2016). Multiculturalism is a significant skill, especially in contemporary educational and occupational settings. The population continuously grows more diverse, which makes cultural competency education more relevant; this necessitates educators to take on the responsibility of ensuring students can perform properly in diverse settings. Many people lack the necessary cultural competency skills

"in a time when these qualities are most needed", and discussions about diversity and culture in the classroom have been found to significantly improve necessary multicultural skills (Hall, & Theriot, 2016).

Education of student support resources

Dr. Gray noted in our interview the necessity of teacher support for student development. He also stated that, in the case that students face discrimination, his experience has found that having a trusted teacher as a resource is the greatest support. Data on student-teacher relationships supports the notion that social-emotional learning is essential for proper education, which is dependent on the educator (Leonard & Woodland, 2022). Teachers who do not have a proper understanding of students' cultural identities and needs are unequipped to properly support them. A study found that in consideration of teacher support, the four themes that emerged were support, caring, diversity, and incivility (Ingraham, Davidson, & Yonge, 2018). Teachers who adequately exhibited these skills retained students with significantly higher academic outcomes. In order for a positive environment to be created, and for teachers to support students as much as possible, discrimination and hostility such as that found in microaggressions must be addressed. Teachers must also have a thorough understanding of their students, their identities, and their needs (Ingraham, Davidson, & Yonge, 2018).

Counselors, similarly, are necessary support resources for students. Data analysis has found the necessity for counselor support, especially in a country growing rapidly more diverse; "it is imperative that school counselors have the knowledge and skills necessary to meet the diverse needs presented by K–12 students" (Dameron et al., 2020). Counselors who took a multicultural competency course performed significantly better on cultural competency assessments, and were therefore much better prepared to support a multicultural student population. Minority students within a student body need support only possible through proper education through cultural competency resources (Dameron et al., 2020).

Support and demonstration from student role models is crucial to their development. Teachers, counselors, parents, and other peers are great influences on students. Acculturation, as aforementioned, is one of the greatest threats to students with minority identities (Rudes & Fantuzzi, 2017). Lower acculturation conflict is possible not only through appropriate conversations and the proper addressing of microaggressions, but through positive support and role models (Kiang, Glatz, & Buchanan, 2017). In both Asian and Latin American parents, parenting competence is tied deeply with lower acculturation, or a greater connection to student identity. Minority students whose cultures were acknowledged and celebrated as on par with the majority culture are less likely to be stigmatized and more likely to feel a sense of belonging (Kiang, Glatz, & Buchanan, 2017).

Plan

A plan encompassing all students' needs, while still being practical, applicable, and appropriate, is essential to the betterment of Berkeley Heights Public Schools students. A thoughtful, flexible, and unique integration of cultural competency education is possible by establishing cultural competency throughout every level of the school: for students, faculty, parents, and the overall district. The research demonstrates not only the effectiveness but the necessity of classroom integration, faculty training, parent support, and the guidance of a director of diversity.

Students: Classroom integration

Cultural competency conversations would be integrated into the classroom. Younger children would understand the importance of culture and inclusion under the guidance of properly trained teachers. Microaggressions would be healthily addressed with an outlook of both removing the harmful statements and building a respectful community. Students would understand basic concepts in terms of inclusion and ensure that no one feels othered.

As students get older, the conversations would become more in-depth and specific. Middle school students are well-equipped to discuss contemporary issues and challenges, as well as explore their own privileges, race, and formal definitions of microaggressions. Conversations about present issues will help students think critically about them and form unique yet respectful opinions on the matter. Creating a culturally respectful environment will reduce instances of disrespect and increase multiculturalism in students. Middle school students, especially those between the ages of twelve and fourteen, develop the deeper insight necessary to comprehend "symbolic concepts and conceptual ideas" (Hilberth & Slate, 2014). During this period, childrens' family structure changes and their peers become a more significant influence in their lives. This is a crucial period to integrate conversations about their culture and identity so that they can gain a better understanding of multiculturalism and their own identities (Hilberth & Slate, 2014). The social-studies and English language-arts classrooms would be appropriate spaces to have these conversations and work them into broader concepts.

In high school, the curriculum would be further expanded to include specific studies and in-depth reading. The classroom curriculum would branch into intellectually stimulating conversations surrounding cultural competency and delve into specific studies. Understanding the struggles of other groups is much more possible through learning about and spending time with others' cultures. Additionally, understanding systemic racism, with activities such as diving into redlining policies and rights struggles worldwide, is appropriate for high school age students. These activities would help students better understand the harm of microaggressions and reduce them by increasing interpersonal skills, multicultural awareness, and overall cultural competency throughout the student body.

Teachers and Counselors: Faculty training

Faculty training would serve two main purposes: firstly, faculty should be well-equipped to educate students and facilitate emotional growth; and secondly, but just as importantly, faculty should be a trusted, well-prepared resource for supporting students. Proper, recognized, and respected certification programs would ensure that teachers are prepared to interact with students from a multicultural standpoint and provide the proper resources and education for their development and education. Counselors should also be well-equipped to support students through cultural-competence and know the proper procedure should an act of aggression occur. Support from teachers will ensure they are more trusted, which will mean that students are more willing to rely on their guidance for their social, emotional, and academic development.

As demonstrated in the aforementioned student experiences, one of the main criticisms with Berkeley Heights Public Schools is the lack of a proper faculty support system. Acts of discrimination from faculty should be handled especially strictly, and an awareness of

microaggressions must be established through proper training. In order for cultural competency to be appropriate and beneficial, faculty must not only be compliant but encouraging. While it is possible that educators may resist the transition to a more culturally competent environment, creating a safe, respectful, and welcoming space for students to learn and grow is the first priority of multicultural education.

Parents: The road to understanding

The greatest potential roadblock in our plan is a possible lack of parental support. Parental involvement is important and significant, especially in a plan which directly involves the betterment of their children. In order to assure parents that these changes to the curriculum are positive, they should be thoroughly educated about the information. As discussed in the methodology section, parent support is crucial to student success and development. Therefore, the Parent-Teacher Organization (PTO) will be highly vocal and remain well-informed about the changes to the district and curriculum. Strong communication through email newsletters will ensure everyone is up-to-date and thoroughly understands the importance of cultural competency education. Additionally, representative feedback is necessary for an equitable and efficient program.

The director of diversity: District-wide cultural competency assurance

Working directly with the superintendent of the district, a well-trained director of diversity would manage the cultural competency program at BHPS. A director of diversity would be well-equipped, experienced, and knowledgeable in working with children of all ages, as well as on topics such as multiculturalism, diversity, and tolerance. The director of diversity's main responsibility is working with the district to support its members and driving initiatives. As demonstrated in the research rationale, programs and support cultivating student emotional development and direct support for their identities are necessary to support their development and reduce aggression among the student body. Under the discretion of certified teachers and the supervision of a director of diversity, an appropriate curriculum can be developed in pre-existing classes. Additionally, part of the director of diversity's responsibilities is being a trusted resource and ensuring student needs are being met. One of their main initiatives would be supporting and educating faculty and students on cultural observances and holidays, for example.

Ensuring adaptability and efficiency: Following-up

Evaluations would serve two main purposes: first, to ensure the cultural competency education is justly supported and effective, and, secondly, to maintain the well-being and happiness of BHPS students. Parent, faculty, and especially student perceptions of cultural competency integration would be monitored. Understanding where the plan is most successful and where it may fall short is essential to developing the most beneficial education possible. Methodology has provided substantial evidence of significant progress as a result of cultural competency, and surveys would demonstrate the positive impact of this education. The goal of our plan is to reduce microaggressions; significantly, following-up would maintain that cultural competency is increasing tolerance and make any necessary adjustments to the curriculum.

Budget

56% of the Berkeley Heights' population annual tax budget goes to schools. The Director of Diversity would be hired by the school board to work directly with the Superintendent

(Township, 2022). The average Director of Diversity's salary is around $94,000 a year with an average total pay of $116,000, and the Berkeley Heights township board would be the most appropriate funder (Glassdoor, 2022). A fair salary would ensure a well-qualified and experienced Director of Diversity. This position is becoming increasingly in-demand in educational and occupational settings. A Director of Diversity would lead the education of faculty and staff in areas they are experienced and well-knowledgeable in.

In Minnesota, cultural competency is a requirement for all educators (MN). The Minnesota Professional Educator Licensing and Standards Board (PELSB) lists government-approved teacher cultural competency training programs. These programs ensure that the values of diversity, inclusion, multiculturalism, and student development are prioritized and that teachers are well-educated. The 13 listed costs average to about $124 a person (MN). The spreadsheet at the link below displays all faculty in the Berkeley Heights township listed on their respective school websites:

Berkeley Heights Public Schools Faculty
Also accessible at: https://tinyurl.com/5xzkup6e.

Ensuring Berkeley Heights Public Schools' educators are properly equipped to educate and guide students ensures that they are knowledgeable in these areas and their appropriate applications. Faculty at every level should operate with a solid understanding of cultural competency. According to the staff listed on the BHPS websites, there are 309 educators. The total estimated cost for teacher certification is $38,300.

The final cost to consider in the implementation of an effective and comprehensive cultural competency plan in the Berkeley Heights Public School system is the cost of curriculum changes. There are many resources available online, and the teachers will be well-prepared to have discussions in classrooms with their certification training. However, certain higher-level classes, such as classes for older students and AP-level courses, may require more in-depth research and materials for engaging and beneficial conversations. As cultural competency would work with pre-existing curricula, substantial amounts of new material would likely be unnecessary. For all courses in all schools in Berkeley Heights, the 2020-2021 total costs for supplies and textbooks were $126 per student, with 2,144 enrolled students (Township, 2022). Berkeley Heights is currently spending $270,144 on classroom materials for students. Preparing for a 5.0% increase in spending budget would ensure around $13,500 of materials for educators.

The following table summarizes the projected budget necessary to implement the plan outlined in this proposal.

Total Projected One-Year Costs

	Cost ($)	**Recurring**
Director of Diversity Salary	116,000	Yearly
Teacher Training	38,300	No (unless in need of teaching license renewal or

		other state policies)
Teaching Materials	13,500	Yearly
Total	167,800	

Implementing a comprehensive cultural competency curriculum into the school district would be not only a necessary change but an investment in Berkeley Heights Public Schools' education. Multiculturalism is a crucial skill, especially as the United States grows more diverse, and cultural competency is essential to developing interpersonal skills and ensuring healthy development of minority students. Investing in cultural competency is investing in the children.

Discussion

A culturally competent community is imperative to the student body's outlook. Currently, multicultural education in Berkeley Heights Public Schools (BHPS) is inadequate and, as a result, discrimination is rampant. Despite being academically strong, BHPS lacks in cultural competency. Minority students often feel othered and are subsequently disadvantaged; the current education lacks the crucial skills in diversity, culture, leadership, and interpersonal relations that stem from multiculturalism. Students suffering from persistent, unacknowledged discrimination are adversely affected mentally, physically, and academically.

By specifically implementing methods of microaggression reduction, student safety and development will be prioritized. A director of diversity will oversee cultural competency initiatives such as the respect of student cultural observances, staff compliance, and student support. Certification programs for counselors and educators would ensure they can properly act in accordance to the higher contemporary multicultural standards. Integrating further education into classrooms would provide students with insightful lessons, supported data, and an open space for them to explore and express their identities.

Surveys would be conducted to ensure thorough support of faculty, parents, and students of the cultural competency program. Adjustments would be made and feedback would be critically considered. This plan prioritizes students, which is why their feedback is imperative. Student success is a necessity in BHPS. Their development is critical, and cultural competency would demonstrate support; effective adjustments would ensure the most comprehensive program.

Reducing microaggressions in schools is an investment in student safety and education. Ensuring students are well-equipped to excel in a diverse world would be another mark of Berkeley Heights' high academic standards. Protecting minority students' futures is simply a necessity. To prioritize multiculturalism is to prioritize BHPS students.

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